Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Deborah Warren's "Mole"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's comparing herself—as a poet—to a mole include

alliteration,
allusion,
coined word,
feminine ending,
iambic pentameter,
imagery,
masculine ending,
metaphor,
meter,
parallelism,
polysyndeton,
rhyme scheme,
simile,
sonnet,
stigmatism,
speaker,
synecdoche,
theme, and
tone.

Deborah Warren's fourteen-line poem should be recognized as a sonnet, a sonnet consisting of two stanzas characterized by their parallel structure: line-by-line syllable count, meter, and the (loose) rhyme scheme.

The young LitCritter will, following the prompt, discover the thematic parallel, beyond the stanzas' similar structure, that has the speaker identifying herself in the second stanza in terms of the mole of the first stanza.

The contestant might rely on the poem's invitation—inherent in its structure—to go point by point through the speaker's comparison.

The mole, the speaker coins, is a geonaut (line 3) that swims "hallways into the sod" (2-3), "carv-[ing] out for himself a single, simple role" (7), while the speaker-as-poet—(line 10's "my habitat is thought")—"grope[s] and sweat[s] and scrabble[s] out a living" (11) that includes—is, apparently, predicated on—proving that the poet can "dig a hole in air" (14) . . . an interesting metaphor for versification. That both the mole's tunneling and the poet's "windy lair" (12) are invisible to pedestrian perspectives finalizes the speaker's comparison. The student might make something of the lack of parallel regarding line 4's "connoisseur of worms," arguing that the mole's interest in *worms*, in the structural and the thematic balance of the two stanzas, suggests the poet's interest in *words*—an interest that might be underscored by the speaker's interjecting *scrabble* (11) into the description of the "windy lair" (12).

Were the contestant given ample time to contemplate the autobiographical nature of this lyrical expression, she or he might enjoy the epiphanic moment embracing the significance of the poet's surname relative to her comparison of the mole's hallways and the poet's own habitat threading through the sonnet.